Philosophy · Metaphysics of God

The Concept of God: Workbook

Omnipotence, omnibenevolence, eternity and omniscience — and whether they fit together.

This workbook goes with the Concept of God slideshow. Each part stands on its own, so you can start wherever you need to. Work through the tasks, then finish with the exam questions in Part 06.

Start here

If you missed the lesson, read these two things first:

1. The Key idea strip at the start of each part — it gives the shape of the argument.

2. The glossary in Part 06 — every key term in one place.

IN THIS WORKBOOK

1. Omnipotence and the paradox of the stone
2. Metaphysical and moral goodness
3. The Euthyphro dilemma
4. God and time: everlasting or eternal
5. Omniscience and human freedom
6. Glossary and exam practice

Part 01 Omnipotence and the paradox of the stone

Key idea If the concept of omnipotence contradicts itself, so does the concept of an omnipotent God.
Aquinas: God can do anything possible; the logically impossible is “not anything at all”.

1.1 Two definitions

Complete the table.

	Definition	One problem or strength
The obvious definition		
Aquinas’ definition		

1.2 Fill the gaps

What is impossible is a _____ in terms: the words used to describe it _____ each other. So a description of a logically impossible power is not a _____ description. The limits of the logically possible are therefore not _____ on God's power.

1.3 Set out the paradox

Write the paradox of the stone as numbered steps, ending with its conclusion.

1.4 Diagnose the replies

Reply 1. This reply says "a stone an omnipotent being can't lift" is logically impossible. In your own words, explain why it **begs the question**.

Reply 2. Explain why, if there is no limit on God's power to lift stones, there is no limit on God's power to create them.

Part 02 Metaphysical and moral goodness

Key idea **Metaphysical goodness** = perfection. **Moral goodness** = a will in accordance with moral values. Plato and Augustine join them: evil is a lack, so the morally good is more real.

2.1 Sort the statements

Write **M** (metaphysical) or **Mo** (moral) beside each.

Statement	M or Mo
God is perfect in every way, including power and knowledge.	
God's will always accords with moral values.	
"God is perfectly good" means "God is perfectly perfect".	
This is the more usual sense of "good".	

2.2 Evil as a lack

Explain, in three linked sentences, how the idea that evil is a "lack" makes moral perfection and metaphysical perfection the same thing.

2.3 Perfection and reality

Name the two ways perfection has been linked to reality.

2.4 Looking ahead

Which sense of goodness does the Euthyphro dilemma put under pressure? Give a reason.

Part 03 The Euthyphro dilemma

Key idea **Option 1** (morality independent of God) costs omnipotence. **Option 2** (morality is whatever God wills) costs goodness. Keep the three objections to Option 2 separate.

3.1 The two options

	Option 1	Option 2
State it		
Which attribute it costs		

3.2 Plato's version

Give two ways our version of the dilemma differs from Plato's.

3.3 Three objections to Option 2

Name each objection and explain what it shows in one sentence.

Objection	What it shows
1.	
2.	
3.	

3.4 Match the reply

Draw a line from each reply to the idea it relies on.

Reply	Relies on…
Goodness depends on God's nature	Water and H_2O
God's will is structured by love	It is impossible for God not to be God
Good is the same property as what God wills	We cannot conceive of God loving differently

3.5 The water analogy

	Water / H_2O	Good / what God wills
Two different concepts?		
One thing in the world?		
Analytically true?		

Which of the three objections to Option 2 does the water analogy answer, and why?

3.6 A further challenge

How can we establish that goodness and God's will are the same thing without an independent standard of goodness? Explain the reply using the water example: does the challenge concern how we **know** what is good, or what goodness **is**?

3.7 Judge it

Which reply to the Euthyphro dilemma do you find strongest? Give one reason it succeeds and one weakness.

Part 04 God and time: everlasting or eternal

Key idea **Everlasting** = in time, throughout all time. **Eternal** = outside time. Boethius (as quoted by Stump and Kretzmann): "the complete possession all at once of illimitable life".

4.1 Why no beginning or end?

Explain how God's self-sufficiency means God's existence has no beginning or end.

4.2 Boethius' four features

An eternal being...	What this means	Fits an everlasting God too?
1. has life		
2. is illimitable		
3. is atemporal		
4. has a special duration		

4.3 Three kinds of simultaneity

Write a definition and your own example for each.

	Definition	Example
T-simultaneity		
E-simultaneity		
ET-simultaneity		

4.4 True or false — then fix it

1. ET-simultaneity is transitive. **T / F**
2. Boethius claims that time goes in a circle. **T / F**
3. On the eternal view, everything God "was" or "will be" always "is". **T / F**

Correct any false statement.

Part 05 Omniscience and human freedom

Key idea The argument is conditional: **if** God knows beforehand, we are not free. The dilemma: free → God not omniscient; not free → God not good. Three solutions: everlasting God, compatibilism, eternity.

5.1 Rebuild the argument

These steps are out of order. Number them 1–6.

No.	Step
	So if God knows what I will do, I cannot refrain from doing it.
	To act freely, I must be able to do the action or refrain from it.
	So if God knows what I will do before I do it, that action is not free.
	If God knows what I will do before I do it, it must be true that I will do it.
	If it is true that I will do it, nothing I can do can prevent it coming true.
	So God cannot know what I will do and it be true that I don't do it.

5.2 Why does free will matter to God's goodness?

5.3 The three solutions

Solution	Core claim	Weakness
God is everlasting		
Compatibilism		
Eternity (Stump and Kretzmann)		

5.4 Spot the confusion

Which premise does the eternity solution say is confused, and what is the confusion?

Part 06 Glossary and exam practice

Glossary

Cover the right-hand column and define each term aloud. Tick the ones you get right.

Term	Meaning	✓
Omnipotence	The power to do anything possible.	
Omniscience	Knowing everything it is possible to know.	
Omnibenevolence	Supreme goodness, metaphysical and/or moral.	
Metaphysical goodness	Goodness as perfection.	
Moral goodness	A will always in accordance with moral values.	
Self-sufficiency	Depending on nothing for existence; lacking nothing.	
Logically impossible	A contradiction in terms; describes nothing at all.	
Coherent	Free of self-contradiction.	
Begging the question	Assuming the truth of a conclusion in order to show it.	
Tautology	A statement true by its own terms, telling us nothing.	
Analytic truth	True in virtue of the meanings of its terms alone.	
Arbitrary	Done for no reason.	
Contingent	True, but could have been otherwise.	
Everlasting	Existing in time, throughout all time.	
Eternal / atemporal	Existing outside time; whole life possessed all at once.	
T-simultaneity	Existing at one and the same time.	
E-simultaneity	Existing in one and the same eternal present.	
ET-simultaneity	Eternal and temporal, each present from either standpoint.	
Transitive	Holds x–y and y–z, so holds x–z.	
Compatibilism	Here: foreknowledge is compatible with free will.	

5-mark questions

Key idea A clear, precise explanation in a short paragraph: define, then explain step by step. Write two in full and plan the rest in bullet points.

1. **Explain the paradox of the stone.** [5 marks]

2. **Explain the Euthyphro dilemma.** [5 marks]

3. **Explain the difference between God being eternal and God being everlasting.** [5 marks]

4. **Explain the difference between metaphysical and moral goodness.** [5 marks]

5. **Explain the argument that God's omniscience is incompatible with human free will.** [5 marks]

12-mark questions

Key idea Set out the problem in full, then the response, linking each step. Plan all three; write one in full.

1. Explain how the paradox of the stone challenges the coherence of the concept of omnipotence, and how one response attempts to defend it. [12 marks]

2. Explain the Euthyphro dilemma and how one response attempts to resolve it. [12 marks]

3. Explain how Stump and Kretzmann's account of eternity attempts to show that God's omniscience is compatible with human free will. [12 marks]

Stage	Q1	Q2	Q3
Key terms defined			
The problem, step by step			
The response, step by step			
How the response meets the problem			

Write one 12-mark answer in full

Question number: ____